Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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The Sadducees

The Sadducees were an important Jewish group made up of priests and their families. They were different from the Pharisees, another Jewish group because the Pharisees were regular ("lay") people who were not priests. They likely lived near Jerusalem and controlled the temple system (Acts 4:1–2; 5:17). These powerful and wealthy leaders (aristocrats) acted as mediators between Rome and Israel (see Josephus, Antiquities 13.10.6; War 2.10.5). They did not have much favor or influence with the people (Josephus, Antiquities 18.1.4).

The term Sadducee probably comes from Zadok, the high priest during the reigns of King David and King Solomon (2 Samuel 8:17; 15:24; 1 Kings 1:8; 32–48). Both words share the same Hebrew root. The earliest historical mention of the Sadducees is during the reign of John Hyrcanus, from 135 to 104 BC, a descendant of the Maccabees (Josephus, Antiquities 13.10.6), but they clearly existed earlier.

Their views about God often differ from those of the Pharisees (Acts 23:8; see also Acts 4:1–2). The Sadducees gave primary authority to the Pentateuch. They rejected the oral tradition valued by the Pharisees. Unlike the Pharisees, the Sadducees did not believe in:

- the resurrection of the dead (see Matthew 22:23–33),
- angelic beings (see Acts 23:8), or
- the concept of final judgment.

The Pharisees, however, strongly believed in the resurrection (coming back to life after death). They even supported Paul against the Sadducees when he was on trial for disturbing the temple (Acts 23:6–10).

Despite their differences, the Pharisees and Sadducees united against Jesus. The Pharisees opposed Jesus because he did not follow their oral traditions. The Sadducees opposed him because he believed in angels, demons, final judgment, and resurrection.

When the temple was destroyed in AD 70, the Sadducees vanished. They did not leave any written records. All our knowledge about the Sadducees comes from their opponents, so we have a limited understanding of them.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 3:7; 16:1–12; 22:23–33; Mark 12:18–27; Luke 20:27–40; Acts 4:1–2; 5:17–18; 23:6–10

Samaritans

Samaria was a region north of Judea. It was centered around the ancient city of Shechem, which is called Sychar in the New Testament. After the conquest of Israel in 722 BC, the cities of Samaria and Shechem were destroyed. People from across the Assyrian empire repopulated the area (2 Kings 17:21–41). These new residents brought many pagan practices, making the land's religious impurity well-known. Over time, the Jewish belief in one God became the main belief, but some things about how people practiced their faith changed. The Samaritans only accepted the Pentateuch (the first five books of the Old Testament) as Scripture. They also worshiped at a new temple on Mount Gerizim above Shechem.

The Samaritans and Jews had a long history of conflict, starting after the Jews returned from exile (see Ezra 4:1–5; Nehemiah 4:1–23). Alexander the Great and later Greek generals made Shechem an important base because they found anti-Jewish allies there. In 128 BC, the Jews destroyed Shechem and burned the Samaritan temple on Mount Gerizim. In AD 6 to 9, the Samaritans fought back by dishonoring the Jerusalem Temple. They scattered human bones from a cemetery during Passover. By the time of Jesus, tension between Judea and Samaria was still strong.

In the time of Jesus, Jews avoided traveling through Samaria because they saw its people as hostile and impure. When Jesus traveled through Samaria and met a Samaritan woman, the tensions of this relationship were clear. Someone living in the first century would hardly expect Jesus and the woman to acknowledge each other, let alone speak. Yet Jesus went beyond his ethnic identity and invited even a Samaritan woman with a bad reputation to believe.

Passages for Further Study

2 Kings 17:21–41; Ezra 4:1–5; Nehemiah 4:1–23; John 4:1–42

Samson

Samson is a good example of God using someone for good even when they do wrong and do not care. Samson rescued Israel without trying or caring. He did not seem to care about his people, family, or God. He only cared about himself. Nonetheless, God placed him in situations where he harmed the Philistines, whom God allowed to oppress sinful Israel.

The first example of how God used Samson happened when he told his parents he wanted to marry a Philistine girl. This surprised his parents because Israelites were commanded not to marry the people of the

land (Deuteronomy 7:1–4; Joshua 23:12–13; see also 2 Corinthians 6:14–18). But Samson insisted even though his parents did not want him to marry a Philistine girl.

On his way to the wedding party, he took honey from a dead lion he had killed earlier. Samson was born a Nazirite, and Nazirites were strictly forbidden from touching a dead body (Numbers 6:1–21). But Samson did not care. He then created a riddle about the lion (Judges 14:14). He bet thirty young Philistine men that they could not solve the riddle. The Philistine men pressured his wife into revealing the answer. As a result, Samson became so angry that he killed thirty Philistine men and took their clothing to settle the bet. God used this self-serving hero to "begin the deliverance of Israel from the hand of the Philistines" (Judges 13:5).

The last important story of Samson's life tells about a woman named Delilah (Judges 16:4–31). She kept bothering Samson until he told her why he was so strong. By telling this secret, Samson broke his special promise to God, called the Nazirite vow. She cut his hair, allowing the Philistines to overpower him. They blinded him, tied him up, and forced him into hard labor.

While in captivity, Samson's hair began to grow back. During a Philistine celebration where they mocked him, he asked to be led to the two main pillars of their temple. He prayed to God for strength to defeat the Philistines and end his own life. He then pulled the temple down, killing about 3,000 Philistines and himself. This act was not for his people or God, but to "pay back the Philistines for my two eyes" (Judges 16:28). Although it was part of God's plan, Samson's story leaves the reader wishing for a better savior.

Passages for Further Study

Judges 13:1–16:31; Hebrews 11:32

Samuel

Samuel lived at the end of the time of the judges and helped lead Israel into the time of kings. He was Israel's last judge (1 Samuel 7:6, 15–17). Samuel is often seen as Israel's first prophet (1 Samuel 3:20; Acts 3:24; 13:20). He served as a priest (see 1 Samuel 2:18). He was a man of great faith (Hebrews 11:32).

Samuel was born because his mother Hannah prayed for him. Samuel's parents traveled each year from Ramah to the sanctuary at Shiloh (1 Samuel 1:3). At the sanctuary, Hannah, who could not have children, prayed for a son and promised to dedicate him to God for full-time service (1 Samuel 1:9–11). God answered her prayer, and Samuel was born (1 Samuel 1:19–20). When Samuel was old enough, Hannah took him to serve in the sanctuary with Eli, the high priest (1 Samuel 1:24–28; 2:11).

Eli's sons were wicked, but Samuel served the Lord. It soon became clear that God spoke more closely with Samuel than with Eli. God warned Samuel about the disaster coming to Eli's family (1 Samuel 3:1–18). This prophecy came true when the Philistines defeated Israel, killed Eli's sons, and took the ark of the covenant (1 Samuel 4:1–22). Later, under Samuel's leadership, the people repented for their idolatry (worship of false gods) and won an important battle against the Philistines (1 Samuel 7:3–17).

As Samuel grew older, it became clear he had the same weakness as Eli. Samuel's sons were evil (1 Samuel 8:1–3), and the people did not want them to lead the nation. Instead, they asked Samuel to appoint a king to lead them in battle against their enemies (1 Samuel 8:4–5). Samuel then anointed Saul as Israel's first king (1 Samuel 9:1–10:24).

The change from the time of the judges to having kings was difficult. Samuel, as a priest, prayed for the people. As a prophet, he criticized Saul for being impatient and disobedient (1 Samuel 13:5–14; 15:12–35). When God rejected Saul as king, Samuel anointed David as God's chosen one (1 Samuel 16:1–13) and protected David from Saul (19:18–24).

Through prayer and determination, Samuel was a faithful leader (Jeremiah 15:1; Hebrews 11:32). He cared deeply for his people and bravely corrected kings and elders. He united Israel from tribal divisions into a strong nation and established a system of rule by kings. He likely wrote The Record of Samuel the Seer (1 Chronicles 29:29). He wrote down how a good king should rule (1 Samuel 10:25). When he died, all of Israel mourned him. He was buried in Ramah, his hometown (1 Samuel 25:1).

Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 1:19–2:11; 3:1–4:1; 7:3–16:13; 19:18–24; 25:1; 28:1–25; Psalm 99:6; Jeremiah 15:1; Acts 3:24; 13:20; Hebrews 11:32

Sarah

Sarah was both Abraham's wife and half-sister (Genesis 11:29; 20:12). She traveled with Abraham from Ur to Haran and then to Canaan (Genesis 11:31; 12:5). Twice, in Egypt and Gerar, Abraham asked Sarah to claim she was his sister, not his wife (Genesis 12:10–20; 20:1–18). He feared he might be killed because of her. Despite Abraham's lack of faith, God protected Sarah both times. This preserved the chosen line through which

God promised to grow the Israelite nation (Genesis 12:2; 17:19).

Sarah is one of several women in the Bible who could not have children but miraculously had a son (see also Genesis 30:22–24; 1 Samuel 1:9–20; 2 Kings 4:14–17; Luke 1:5–25). After God made several promises, Sarah became pregnant and gave birth to Isaac. Sarah was ninety years old when this happened, showing God's power to do what seems impossible (compare Genesis 17:17; 21:1–5). Her name changed from Sarai to Sarah when God promised Isaac's birth (Genesis 17:15–16). Sarah is honored for her faith, even though she laughed at the prediction of Isaac's birth (Genesis 18:10–15). This happened twenty-five years after God's first promise to Abraham.

Sarah died at age 127 and was buried in the cave Abraham bought at Machpelah (Genesis 23). She is known as the mother of the nation of Israel (Isaiah 51:2), just as Abraham is its father. She plays a key role in stories about Abraham's faith (see Romans 4:19). She symbolizes the freedom Christians have (as children of Sarah, the free woman) through faith in Christ (see Galatians 4:21–31). Peter uses her as an example of holy submission (1 Peter 3:5–6). The writer of Hebrews presents Sarah as an example of faith, for she believed in God's ability to keep his promises (Hebrews 11:11–12). Her life shows that God is faithful, even if his timing does not always match our expectations.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 11:29–31; 12:10–20; 17:15–22; 18:9–15; 20:1–18; 21:1–13; 23:1–20; Isaiah 51:2; Romans 4:19; 9:6–9; Galatians 4:21–31; Hebrews 11:11–12; 1 Peter 3:6

Satan

The book of Job mentions "the satan" as part of the heavenly court (Job 1:6; 2:1). (The heavenly court is a gathering in heaven where God meets with his angels.) In Hebrew, satan means an adversary or accuser in court (see Job 1–2; Zechariah 3:1). God sometimes uses angels as adversaries for righteous judgment and to oppose wrongdoers (for example, Numbers 22:22, 32, where satan is often translated as "oppose"; see also 1 Kings 22:19–23).

The Old Testament suggests the accuser has a demonic nature. But it was in the time between the Old and New Testaments that Satan became associated with the serpent in Eden (see Wisdom of Solomon 2:24). The New Testament calls the chief demon "Satan" (Revelation 20:2). The New Testament uses other names like:

- The devil (Matthew 4:1–11)
- The tempter (1 Thessalonians 3:5)
- Beelzebul, the prince of demons (see notes at Matthew 12:24; Luke 11:15)
- The evil one (Matthew 13:19, 38; 1 John 2:13–14; 3:12; 5:18)
- Belial (see note at 2 Corinthians 6:15)
- The deceiver (Revelation 12:9)
- A huge red dragon with seven heads (Revelation 12:3, 9)
- Ancient serpent (Revelation 20:2)
- A murderer and the father of lies (John 8:44)

Satan did many evil things against God and people. He made David count his army when he should not have (1 Chronicles 21:1; compare 2 Samuel 24:1). Satan tried to tempt Jesus to do wrong and later helped Judas betray Jesus (Mark 1:12–13; John 13:27). He wanted to test Peter's faith like he tested Job (Luke 22:31). He trapped people in sin (Acts 26:17–18). He used lies to oppose God's people (1 Corinthians 7:5; 2 Corinthians 11:14). In the end, God will defeat and imprison Satan, overcoming the adversary of God's people (Revelation 12:9; 20:2, 10).

Passages for Further Study

Numbers 22:22, 32; 1 Chronicles 21:1; Job 1:6–2:7; Zechariah 3:1–4; Matthew 4:1–10; 12:24; 13:19, 38–39; 16:23; Mark 1:13; 4:15; Luke 4:6; 10:17–20; 11:15; 22:3, 31; John 8:44; 12:31; 13:2, 27; 16:11; Acts 13:9–10; 26:17–18; Romans 16:20; 1 Corinthians 7:5; 2 Corinthians 2:10–11; 4:4; 6:15; 11:13–15; 1 Thessalonians 3:5; 2 Thessalonians 2:2–12; Hebrews 2:14; James 4:7; 1 Peter 5:8; 1 John 2:13–14; 3:12; 5:18; Revelation 12:3, 9; 20:2, 10

Saul

Saul was the first king of Israel. God and the people chose him, but he failed greatly due to his lack of confidence in himself and God. Saul was a complicated person. At times, we feel sorry for him because of his struggles. However, he often caused his own problems, bringing sadness and trouble to those close to him.

Saul was the son of a wealthy landowner. He became king without expecting or wanting to be one. The people wanted a king to lead them in battles, so they were pleased with Saul, who was taller than anyone else (1 Samuel 10:23). However, their military problems were overwhelming, and Saul lacked confidence as a military leader. Without the prophet Samuel and Saul's son Jonathan, Saul's reign might have ended in complete disaster.

Saul upset God by making quick promises without thinking during wartime (1 Samuel 14:16–46). He also

performed sacrifices before battle instead of waiting for Samuel (1 Samuel 13:7b–14). He disobeyed God's command to destroy all the people and goods of the Amalekites (1 Samuel 15:1–35). Because of this, God decided to remove Saul from being king. God sent Samuel to choose David as the new king by pouring sacred oil on his head. Soon, Saul became very suspicious of David, who was his son's best friend and his most loyal servant. Saul became a cruel ruler who refused to give up control no matter what. He spent much time and effort trying to catch and kill David.

Saul was injured in a battle against the Philistines and then killed himself with his sword. His death was the result of God's judgment. Even though David had spent much time running from Saul, he honored the first king and his son Jonathan with a sincere speech (2 Samuel 1:17–27).

Passages for Further Study

1 Samuel 9:1–11:15; 13:1–31:13; 2 Samuel 1:1–27; 1 Chronicles 9:35–10:14

Simon Peter

Simon Peter was the main leader among the twelve closest followers of Jesus. These followers are called apostles. After Jesus died, Simon Peter became the main person to speak officially for early Christians in Jerusalem. He was the apostle mainly responsible for sharing the good news about Jesus with the Jews (Galatians 2:7–8).

The Hebrew name Simeon (spelled in English as Simon) was likely his original name. Cephas is the transliteration of an Aramaic name that Jesus gave him, meaning "rock." In Greek, this is translated as Petros (English "Peter"; see Matthew 16:17–18; John 1:42).

Bethsaida was Peter's hometown (John 1:44). Peter later moved to Capernaum. He was married (1 Corinthians 9:5). When Jesus visited Peter's home, he healed Peter's mother-in-law (Matthew 8:14–15; Mark 1:29–31; Luke 4:38–39).

Peter and his brother Andrew were fishermen. Jesus called them to be among his first disciples, along with their fishing partners, James and John (Matthew 4:18–22; Mark 1:16–20; see also Luke 5:1–11; John 1:35–51). They were ordinary working men with little formal education (Acts 4:13).

Peter's name appears first on every list of the twelve apostles (Matthew 10:2; Mark 3:16; Luke 6:14; Acts 1:13). Along with the brothers James and John, Peter was part of a close group of disciples who were with Jesus during special events, including:

- when Jesus healed Jairus's daughter (Mark 5:37; Luke 8:51),
- when the appearance of Jesus changed to show his glory (Matthew 17:1–2; Mark 9:2; Luke 9:28–29), and
- when Jesus prayed in the garden of Gethsemane (Matthew 26:37; Mark 14:33).

Peter was bold and impulsive (Matthew 26:33; Mark 14:29; Luke 5:8; 22:33; John 13:36–37; 21:7). He was the first disciple to declare his belief in Jesus as God's chosen leader, the Messiah (or "Christ," Matthew 16:15–16; Mark 8:29; Luke 9:20). When Jesus talked about his upcoming death, Peter told him he was wrong. This did not match Peter's idea of the Messiah. Jesus strongly corrected Peter for this (Matthew 16:21–23; Mark 8:31–33). However, Jesus said Peter would be a key person to help establish the church (Matthew 16:18–19).

Peter secretly entered the high priest's courtyard when they took Jesus there for questioning. People recognized Peter, partly because of his Galilean accent, and challenged him. He strongly denied knowing Jesus, just as Jesus had predicted, despite Peter's saying earlier that he would never do so (Matthew 26:69–75; Mark 14:66–72; Luke 22:54–62). Peter immediately felt deep remorse (Matthew 26:33–35; Mark 14:29–31; Luke 22:31–34).

After hearing about the resurrection of Jesus, Peter was one of the first to run to the tomb to check if it was true (John 20:3–7). He seems to have been the first of the 12 apostles to whom the risen Jesus appeared (Luke 24:33–34; 1 Corinthians 15:5). Much of the conversation in John 21 was between Jesus and Peter. Jesus encouraged him to "feed my lambs" (John 21:15–17).

After the Holy Spirit came on the Day of Pentecost (Acts 2:1–13), Peter became the main apostle to speak officially for the early Christians. From then on, as noted in Acts 2:14–12:25, he played a key role in spreading the good news about Jesus in Judea. He boldly preached to the crowds (Acts 2:14–41; 3:12–26). He healed people (Acts 3:1–11; 5:12–16; 9:32–43). He spoke fearlessly to the authorities even when arrested (Acts 4:1–20; 5:26–32). He miraculously escaped from prison twice (Acts 5:18–25; 12:6–11). He also led in managing the quickly growing community of disciples (Acts 5:3–11).

Peter was the first to share the good news about Jesus with non-Jews (Acts 10:1–48; see Matthew 16:18). He played a key role in the Jerusalem council about non-Jewish converts. He argued that non-Jews should not have to follow the law of Moses. Instead, they should

be accepted based on their faith in Jesus alone (Acts 15:7–11). Later, when visiting Antioch, he was inconsistent about this. Paul strongly criticized him for it (Galatians 2:11–16).

Peter brought his wife on some mission trips (1 Corinthians 9:5). We do not know many other details about Peter's later life and missionary work. He might have spent time in Corinth (1 Corinthians 1:12; 3:22). Early tradition says that Peter was crucified (killed by being nailed to a cross) in Rome during Nero's persecution of Christians in AD 64–65. Jesus said this would happen (John 21:18–19). The tradition that he was crucified upside-down is less certain.

Peter likely provided the information that Mark recorded in his Gospel. Mark probably learned this while helping Peter with his evangelistic work in Italy near the end of Peter's life. Tradition also says that Peter wrote 1 Peter (from Rome, referred to as "Babylon," 1 Peter 5:13) and 2 Peter.

In the New Testament, Peter shows how Jesus forgives and restores those who have failed him. Jesus can still use them for his glory.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 4:18–20; 8:14; 10:2; 14:28–31; 15:15; 16:16–19, 22–23; 17:1–4, 24–27; 18:21; 19:27; 26:33–45, 58, 69–75; Mark 1:16–18, 29–30, 36–37; 3:16; 5:37; 8:29–33; 9:2–6; 10:28; 11:21; 13:3–4; 14:29–42, 54, 66–72; 16:7–8; Luke 4:38; 5:3–10; 6:14; 8:45, 51; 9:20, 28–33; 12:41; 18:28; 22:8, 31–34, 55–62; 24:12, 34; John 1:40–42, 44; 6:8, 68; 13:6–10, 24, 36–38; 18:10–11, 15–18, 25–27; 20:2–6; 21:2–21; Acts 1:1–12:25; 15:7–11; Galatians 2:7–16; 1 Peter 1:1–5:14; 2 Peter 1:1–3:18

Solomon

Solomon was the third king of Israel and the second son of David and Bathsheba (2 Samuel 12:13–25). He ruled for forty years, from 971 to 931 BC. When Solomon first became king he had strong faith in God. But, he ended his life worshiping idols, which led to the destruction of his kingdom.

As King David neared death, his son Adonijah tried to make himself king with support from the priest Abiathar and the general Joab (1 Kings 1:1–53). However, the kingdom was promised to Solomon (1 Kings 1:17; see 2 Samuel 12:24–25; 1 Chronicles 28:4–7). So, Bathsheba and the prophet Nathan told David about Adonijah's plans. David quickly arranged for Solomon to be officially declared king. Then David advised Solomon to follow God faithfully (1 Kings 2:1–9).

Solomon loved God and asked for his help. God offered him a gift, and Solomon chose wisdom over long life, riches, or fame. As a result, God granted Solomon all of these:

- He ruled wisely (1 Kings 3:16–28).
- He earned worldwide respect (1 Kings 4:20–34).
- He wrote the Song of Songs, most of Proverbs, and Ecclesiastes.

Rabbis (Jewish teachers) said these books reflect three stages of his life: "When a man is young he composes songs; when he grows older he makes sententious remarks; and when he becomes an old man he speaks of the vanity of things" (Midrash Rabbah). He also built the temple in Jerusalem and his palace. He expanded trade and increased Israel's wealth and security. His wisdom and wealth were famous. The queen of Sheba visited Jerusalem to see him herself (1 Kings 10:1–29).

Solomon made many foreign alliances and married many foreign women, starting with the daughter of Egypt's pharaoh (1 Kings 3:1). His foreign wives led him away from God and toward idols. Later in life, Solomon, once wise, became very foolish under their influence. He worshiped false gods and treated his people badly. As a result, God used Jeroboam to take away a large part of Solomon's kingdom.

Even so, the New Testament remembers Solomon's wisdom and glory as the example by which others are judged. Jesus is the incarnation of God's wisdom (or God's wisdom in human form), which greatly exceeds Solomon's (Matthew 12:42; Luke 11:31).

Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 12:24–25; 1 Kings 1:1–11:43; 2 Chronicles 1:1–9:31; Psalms 72:1–20; 127:1–5; Proverbs 1:1; Matthew 6:28–30; 12:42; Luke 11:31; 12:27

The Son of Man

The Hebrew and Aramaic phrase "son of man" means "human being." However, the figure in Daniel 7:13–14, who is "like the Son of Man," seems to be more than just a human being. His exact identity is not given, but his role is clear. The Most High has chosen him to rule an eternal and universal kingdom over all nations. He also represents his people, the holy people of the Most High. They will share in this son of man's kingdom over all peoples and nations (see Daniel 7:22).

The scene around this son of man shows his godly characteristics. The description "coming with the clouds of heaven" in Daniel 7:13 tells us that he comes from heaven (compare Psalm 68:4; 97:2; Nahum 1:3).

In the book of Exodus, the Lord God covered himself with a cloud (Exodus 19:9). God's people will rise into the clouds when Jesus returns (1 Thessalonians 4:17), just as he was taken into a cloud when he went up to heaven (Acts 1:9). This son of man receives his kingdom with humility and holiness, not by arrogantly seizing it. He is the opposite in character to the little horn (Daniel 7:8).

Jesus calls himself the Son of Man (Matthew 24:30; 26:24; Mark 13:26; Luke 21:27; John 12:34; see also Acts 7:56; Hebrews 2:6; Revelation 1:13; 14:14). Revelation 1:7 also connects this figure to Jesus Christ, who was pierced for our sins. God the Father gave Jesus all authority and power to rule everything and to reach people from all nations and kingdoms (Daniel 7:14; Matthew 28:18; 19–20). God called Abraham to create a great nation through his people and to bless all nations through him (Genesis 12:1–3). Jesus fulfilled this promise.

Passages for Further Study

Daniel 7:13–14; Matthew 24:30; 26:24; Mark 13:26; Luke 21:27; John 12:34; Revelation 1:13; 14:14

Stephen

Stephen was an early Christian whose life was an example for others to follow. Because he spoke bravely about his faith, the Jewish authorities arrested and killed him. He is known as the first Christian martyr. This means he was the first person to die for his faith in Jesus.

Stephen was one of seven men chosen to help distribute food to needy Christians in Jerusalem (Acts 6:1–6). Of the seven men chosen, Stephen was special because he was "full of faith and the Holy Spirit" (Acts 6:5). Showing God's grace and power in a special way, he performed miracles (Acts 6:8). He was brave in telling others about Jesus and was good at explaining and protecting Christian beliefs (Acts 6:9–10). Because he spoke so openly about Jesus, the Jewish leaders arrested him. They brought him before their ruling council (called the Sanhedrin) to question him (Acts 6:9–12).

Witnesses accused Stephen of speaking against the holy temple and the law of Moses (Acts 6:13–14; compare Mark 13:2; John 2:19; 4:21). Stephen defended himself before the Jewish ruling council (Acts 7:1–53). He talked about Israel's long history of resisting God and his servants—first Moses and now the Prophet whom Moses had predicted (Acts 7:51–53). The Jewish authorities, angry at Stephen's bold claims, dragged him outside the city and stoned him to death (Acts 7:54–60). As he died, Stephen prayed for their forgiveness (Acts 7:60).

Stephen's brave testimony led to the first persecution of early Christians (Acts 8:1–3). This persecution caused the good news to spread further as believers left Jerusalem and shared the message of Jesus wherever they went (Acts 8:4; 11:19–21). After Stephen died for his faith, Christians began sharing the good news about Jesus beyond their homeland of Judea.

Stephen's life shows us that being a faithful Christian can lead to strong opposition. Speaking boldly for Jesus may be costly (see Revelation 2:10, 13), but nothing can stop the church from growing (see Matthew 16:18; Acts 8:1–4).

Passages for Further Study

Acts 6:5–8:2; 11:19; 22:20